

already watch TV on any computer with a TV tuner card, with this kind of convenience, it probably won't be long before the DRM, RIAA and MPAA guys come in.

## IM MERGING

## Even three make a company

Microsoft, AOL and Yahoo! have announced an agreement that will link their instant messaging networks. This, however, is for business users only. The combined network would get to more than 400 million customers globally. The agreement is aimed at making instant messaging as widely used as e-mail is, without the network compatibility problems associated.

"This agreement represents the dawn of the next era for instant messaging, which will unleash the true potential of real-time communication and collaboration in the workplace," said Edmund Fish, senior vice president at America Online.



The new system will be based on Microsoft's Live Communications Server 2005. It will serve as the hub that will connect the messaging systems.

Nate Root, a senior analyst with Forrester Research, says: "This is a very significant announce-

ment. The value here is for corporations. Corporations will now have the ability to span the instant messaging landscape."

However, for now at least, the three companies have no plans to integrate instant messaging outside corporate workplaces. "What this does not do," Root said, "is the holy grail of instant messaging, which is to allow anybody on any network to send a message to anybody on any other network."

The new service being would have features that include recording and saving of messages sent over IM, and a guarantee of secure communications, which the free IM services do not provide.

Corporate use of instant messaging is widespread, but it remains to be seen whether companies will be willing to actually spend on the new service, thereby formalising instant messaging.



## Trust busters

Recently, we decided to buy a pack of VCDs from Indiatimes Shopping. Registration done, we were the



proud owners of a 15 per cent discount coupon. A few clicks and pages later, it was time to enter the coupon number and wait... Imagine our surprise when it threw up an "Already used" error!

We then scoured the site for a Customer Support link. There wasn't one. So we sent a whining e-mail via its Feedback Forum. A week passed and a month thereafter. No sign of a reply. We caught sight of their toll-free shopping number and dialed to give them a 'blast'.

But no sooner had we dialed than a curt, cold voice (reminded us of ice) 'informed' us that we can just "place" orders not "complain" about one! Not cool at all.

There are variants of this method - in some cases, different algorithms in the pool combine and discard properties according to the Darwinian principles of crossover and mutation, in order to arrive at the optimal algorithm.

The relation to Net downloads is that a lot of the data transmitted over networks is repeated. If all data were to be transferred afresh each time, it would mean a waste of resources. To solve this problem, data is cached at certain servers, and for a certain period of

time. But where, and for how long, is not a trivial problem. It is for this problem that the genetic algorithms were developed.

The scheme could, at some point in the future, be

## GENDER



## BENDERS

### Kartik Iyer v/s Sapna Lokahnde Connecting routine peripherals —mouse, monitor and keyboard



Kartik, 19, commerce undergraduate, is confidence personified. He connects the mouse and keyboard in one stroke. But he gets confused over why the monitor cord is double-ended. Stalemate. It takes over a minute till he solves the mystery. He inserts it into the right slot. Finally. The machine hums to life after he switches on the mains.



Sapna Lokhande, 19, a commerce undergraduate, laughs nervously before she begins. Did she expect something tough? She does a mental toss-up, and chooses the mouse first. The keyboard is also connected. But Sapna, too, is stuck at the monitor cord. Finally, everything falls into place.

## DOWNLOAD

## And now, evolution for technology

Darwin's theories of evolution may soon dictate how soon a download completes.

Scientists at the University of Karlsruhe in Germany are developing genetic algorithms that would help in speeding up Net downloads.

A genetic algorithm is one that has been "bred" by the principles of Darwinian evolution: for example, from an initial pool of algorithms, the ones that give the best results are chosen for the next iteration, and so on, until one algorithm emerges the winner. This is the "optimal", or best, algorithm.

**Scientists in Germany are developing genetic algorithms that would expedite Internet downloads**